

GENDER

Anuradha vs. Bhuvan



BENDERS

How Many English Pages Can You Access On The Web?

00:06:15:43



Anuradha's cerebral cogs and wheels got into action when we told her about the task. She headed to Google.com and typed in "English +Web Pages". The count? 63 million. Not figuring where to find the answer, she opened each result successively, without realising that the result count is displayed just below the search tab. We gave her a hint. With renewed energy, she rephrased her search term to "English" and then "number +English" to get 4.5 billion. And that was the end of that.

00:07:20:00



When we told Bhuvan what he needed to do, he seemed very confident indeed. All smiles, he Googled "Web Pages +English". He rephrased his terms a couple of times but didn't get a decent answer. Then thought a different search engine would give better results. Alltheweb.com didn't help either. We gave him the same clue we gave Anuradha. Bhuvan used his first phrase to see the count he had missed—872 million—a far cry from 26 billion, which is what you get when you Google "+the". Anuradha wins—for time and for getting closer to what we wanted!

down the cost of manufacture. "Our 3G handset initiative will allow... people to take advantage of the video clips, mobile music, Internet access... now enjoyed by... users in the developed world," said Rob Conway, chief executive of the GSMA.

The programme will encourage phone suppliers to compete to design 3G

handsets that meet the mobile operators' common requirements. The GSMA will endorse the winning handset, which will then be widely deployed by mobile operators participating in the programme.

This latest initiative builds on the success of the GSMA's earlier Emerging Market Handset (EMH) programme, which created

a new segment of ultra-low-cost phones with wholesale prices of less than Rs 1,400 for entry-level handsets. The GSMA has said that the availability of such handsets has telecom-enabled millions of people. In India, the EMH programme has helped bring the wholesale cost of GSM handsets down by more than 25 per cent since last year.

Despite such a fall in prices, the GSMA estimates that there are about a billion people worldwide who won't be able to afford a handset for the foreseeable future. The GSMA, through its Development Fund, is looking at how to extend the benefits of mobile communications to this segment. To this end, the Fund is financing a series of pilot projects in Africa and Asia that enable locals to set up payphone businesses or Internet cafes; it has helped Airtel launch a pilot project in UP that equips entrepreneurs with handsets specially adapted to function as payphones.

In regards to 3G, the Press Trust of India quoted telecom minister Dayanidhi Maran as saying, "The Government has to make some money out of it (the 3G spectrum)... (and) make it very competitive and does not want people to sit over spectrum." He did not mention how 3G should be priced, leaving it to the TRAI. "Government will take a decision after TRAI comes out with its recommendations." Let's see how soon that happens.

MICROSOFT TO END SUPPORT

Death Knell Sounds For Windows 98

Come July 11 and Microsoft Corporation will be formally ending support for the Windows 98 line of operating systems—Windows 98, Windows 98 SE and Windows ME. You probably sit at a much faster machine, but PCs on the lower side of 128 MB RAM and a 400 MHz CPU still work best with this dated OS.

After the termination of support, no new security patches, bug fixes or updates will be available. This does not mean the end of the world—one just needs to be extra careful when surfing high-risk sites, opening unknown .exe files, and so on. A firewall is a good idea.

Extensive help can be found on forums. If you get a Win98 error message, you can type in the error into a search engine and follow the links to forum threads. Two particularly helpful forums are www.computing.net and www.annoyances.org.

Microsoft had announced the end of support for Win98 and ME earlier, and had pulled back that decision; this, according to research analyst firm Gartner, was due to fears of users migrating to Linux. Win98 therefore got a new lease of life, but this time it seems to be for real. The real concern is for small corporates who cannot be lax about security, and who will be forced to upgrade.

Google Spreadsheets

Encroaching further on Microsoft's territory, Google has a new online spreadsheet offering—cleverly named Google Spreadsheets—and everyone's talking about it. The interface is intuitive, and you can work on a spreadsheet as soon as you log in to spreadsheets.google.com. About the unique features: you can choose who can edit or view a spreadsheet you created just by typing in their e-

mail address. Multiple people can view and edit a spreadsheet online simultaneously. You can view who's accessing your spreadsheet, who's editing it, and chat with them right there! Google auto-saves your spreadsheet, freeing you from the worry of power failures and system crashes. You can also save spreadsheets on your system in formats such as XLS, CSV, and HTML.

Buzzword
of the MONTH